

A Soft Introduction to CMA-ES Technique

Optimization Algorithm Team

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September 10, 2026

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Introduction

Optimization with Gradient Descents

Random Search

Evolution Strategy: (μ, λ) -ES

Ill-Conditioned Quadratic

Introduction

The objective of the study is to understand the progression

random search → evolution strategy → adaptive Gaussian search → CMA-ES

After: we shall see how important it is to adapt a full covariance matrix can make the algorithm nearly insensitive to rotations and anisotropic scalings of the search landscape.

Optimization with Gradient Descents

Let $D \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ and $f : D \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. We want to minimize the function f

$$\min_{x \in D} f(x) \quad (1)$$

If f is smooth (i.e., continuously differentiable) then to solve (1), we can use gradient descent methods which generate the solution by updating

$$x_{n+1} = x_n - \sigma \nabla f(x_n)$$

Search information

The optimization algorithm uses gradient to go to the descent directions.

f is differentiable



Gradient/Derivatives

f is differentiable



Gradient/Derivatives

" f is not
differentiable!"



f is differentiable



Gradient/Derivatives

" f is not
differentiable!"



Derivative-Free
Optimization

Random Search

How can we reach the optimizer?

Random Search ¹

Having a starting point $m_0 \Rightarrow$ generate random points around $m_0 \Rightarrow$ calculate the function values f

This is as stated " Finding a needle in an n-dimensional haystack" Korn [1966], White [1970].

Search information

The optimization algorithm uses a set of randomly generated points based on probability distribution.

¹White [1970]

Evolution Strategy: (μ, λ) -ES

Algorithm 1: $(1, \lambda)$ -ES Iteration: Isotropic Search

Input: A point $m_0 \in \mathbb{R}^d$, step size $\sigma > 0$, population size λ

```
1 for  $k \leftarrow 1$  to  $n$  do
2   for  $i \leftarrow 1$  to  $\lambda$  do
3     Sample  $Z_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I_d)$ 
4     Compute  $X_i \leftarrow m_k + \sigma Z_i$  //  $X_i \sim \mathcal{N}(m_0, \sigma^2 I_d)$ 
5   Compute fitness value  $f(X_1), \dots, f(X_\lambda)$ 
6    $i^* \leftarrow \arg \min_{i \in \{1, \dots, \lambda\}} f(X_i)$ 
7    $m_{k+1} \leftarrow X_{i^*}$ 
8 return  $m_n$ 
```

Algorithm 2: (μ, λ) -ES Iteration: Isotropic Search

Input: A point $m_0 \in \mathbb{R}^d$, step size $\sigma > 0$, population size λ , number of selected parent $\mu \leq \lambda$, weighted factor ω_i s.t. $\sum_{i=1}^{\mu} \omega_i = 1$.

1 **for** $k \leftarrow 1$ **to** n **do**

2 **for** $i \leftarrow 1$ **to** λ **do**

3 $Z_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I_d)$

4 $X_i = m_k + \sigma Z_i$

5 Compute $f(X_i)$ and sort offspring by fitness:

$$X_{1:\lambda}, X_{2:\lambda}, \dots, X_{\lambda:\lambda},$$

where $X_{1:\lambda}$ is the best, $X_{2:\lambda}$ is the second-best, and so on.

6 Choose μ best candidates and recombine

$$m_{n+1} = \sum_{i=1}^{\mu} \omega_i X_{i:\lambda}.$$

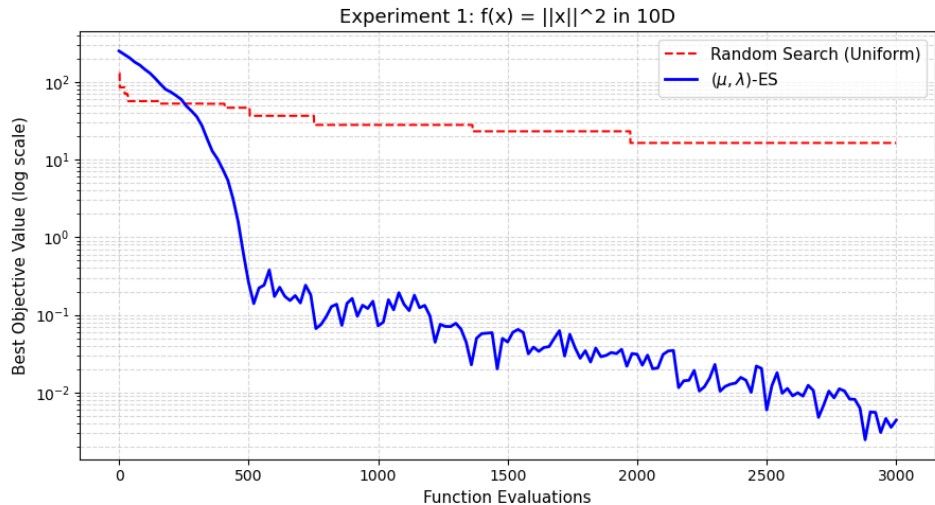


Figure 1: Comparison between random search with uniform distribution and (μ, λ) -ES.

III-Conditioned Quadratic

Anisotropic level set

- With covariance adaptation, we see that to obtain the solution it goes through to the optimal solution.
- While the isotropic search cannot. It more or less is taking a detour to obtain the solution.
- A central observation is that isotropic mutation is inefficient when the successful search from a thin elongated ellipsoid.

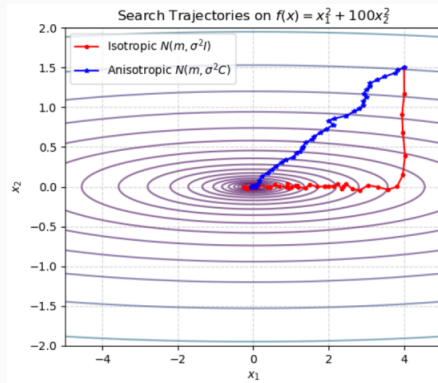


Figure 2: Function f has anisotropic level set. (Steep valley in x_2 and flat in x_1).

Updated Search Information

The optimization algorithm uses λ randomly generated points called *offsprings* and

Anisotropic search

In stead of sampling from

$$X \sim \mathcal{N}(m, \sigma^2 I),$$

we consider the offspring of the form

$$X \sim \mathcal{N}(m, \sigma^2 C)$$

where C is symmetric positive definite.

What does the covariance matrix C do here?

A picture here similar to the one that prof explained in the first day.

The picture equals =

- The matrix C determines the shape of and orientation of the search distribution.
- The idea of covariance is relatively simple: Directions in which successful stels have repeated ly occurred should receive larger variance in the future generations.

Search directions

The optimization algorithm learns not only where to search thought the starting point m but also how to to search through C .

References

- R.C. White. *A survey of random methods for parameter optimization*. EUT report. E, Fac. of Electrical Engineering. Technische Hogeschool Eindhoven, 1970.
- Granino Arthur Korn. *Random-Process Simulation and Measurements*. McGraw-Hill, New York, 1966.

**Thank you for your attentions!!!
:-)**